Revision Date:
04/01/2024

Background:
Customers that experience a household (HH) misfortune, such as a power outage, fire, or disaster, may lose food that was purchased with CalFresh benefits. Replacement benefits are available to help customers replace food that was lost due to the misfortune.

Purpose:
This section details the policy for replacement benefits due to HH misfortune. This section is being revised to update the guidance on issuing replacement benefits.

Policy:
HHs can request replacement benefits when food purchased with CalFresh is destroyed due to a HH misfortune. The HH has ten days from the date the loss occurred to request replacement benefits and submit the signed Replacement or Disaster Supplement Affidavit (CF 303). The CF 303 may be submitted online, in person, by phone, mail or fax and is the only form that must be completed by the customer. If the tenth day falls on a weekend or holiday, and the CF 303 is received the business day after the weekend or holiday, it will be considered timely. If the CF 303 is not received within 10 days from of the date the loss occurred, no replacement benefits will be issued.

1. Verification
The HHs misfortune shall be verified. Verification methods include, but are not limited to, collateral contact or documentation from a community agency, utility company, or fire department. When verification is unavailable, the customer's statement on the CF 303 is acceptable. Verification of misfortunes impacting entire zip codes will be shared with staff when available.

2. Processing Replacement Benefits
Replacement benefits must be issued within two days of receiving the CF 303. When information is questionable and further clarification is needed, an additional seven days may be allowed to issue benefits. Replacement benefits will equal the amount of food the HH lost but cannot exceed more than one month's allotment. Refer to Job Aid (JA) Issuance – Replace CalFresh Benefits for instructions on issuing replacement benefits.

3. Multiple Replacement Requests
HHs may make multiple requests for replacement benefits for the **same** misfortune; however, all requests must be made within 10 days from the date the loss occurred. When multiple requests are made for the same misfortune, the total amount of benefits replaced cannot exceed the HHs monthly allotment for the month in which the misfortune occurred. HHs may make multiple requests for replacement benefits for **separate** HH misfortunes; however, all requests must be made within 10 days of the loss of food. When multiple requests are made for separate misfortunes, the total amount of benefits replaced may exceed the HHs monthly allotment for the month in which the misfortune occurred.

Example: Multiple Request - Same HH Misfortune	
Scenario	On October 5 there is a power outage and a HH experiences a total loss of food that was purchased with all their October CalFresh benefits. Their monthly allotment for October is $694.

Outcome	On October 6, the HH reports the food loss due to the power outage but only requests a replacement of $394. They are issued replacement benefits in the amount of $394. Three days later, the HH requests an additional replacement of $400 to cover the remaining food that was lost due to the power outage. The HH may only be issued an additional $300 in replacement benefits, because the total amount of benefits replaced cannot exceed October's allotment of $694.
Example: Multiple Request - Separate HH Misfortune	
Scenario	On October 5 there is a power outage and, a HH experiences a partial loss of food purchased with CalFresh benefits. On October 25 the same HH has a fire in their home and loses all food purchased with their CalFresh benefits. Their monthly allotment for October is $960.
Outcome	On October 6 the HH reports the food loss due to the power outage and requests a replacement of $600 worth of food that was lost. They are issued replacement benefits in the amount of $600. On October 25, the HH experienced a separate HH misfortune, the fire, and reports the food loss including some of the food that was purchased with the original replacement. The HH requests a replacement of $500 worth of food that was lost. They may be issued a replacement benefit in the amount of $500.

4. Notices

Staff must complete the County Use Only Section of the CF 303 to document the approval/denial and amount of replacement benefits issued. Once completed, staff shall mail a copy of the CF 303 to the HH. Image a copy of the completed CF 303 into the case file to document the actions taken.

References:

MPP 63-603; ACL 21-15; ACL 19-95; ACL 18-125; ACL 87-158
JA Issuance – Replace CalFresh Benefits

Sunset Date:

This policy will be reviewed for continuance by 04/30/2027.

Approval for Release:

3-27-24

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